the movement of submarines. He retreated but did not surrender and would keep fighting in the days to come.[20]

They then discussed the content of Khrushchev's letters to Kennedy and Castro. In the draft of Khrushchev's letter to Castro, the Soviet leader no longer claimed victory. "It was halfway successful, and half not," went the line of argument. "It is positive that the whole world is focused on Cuba.… Time will pass, and if needed, it [weaponry] will again be sent." The Presidium instructed Khrushchev to ignore Kennedy's demand to remove nuclear weapons from Cuba. The protocol read as follows in that regard: "Regardless of the class of weaponry, it has been delivered. It has been delivered with the aim of defending Cuba against aggression." If Kennedy wanted Khrushchev to remove nuclear weapons from Cuba, Khrushchev wanted Kennedy to lift or, rather, not introduce, the blockade. "I hope," went Khrushchev's letter to Kennedy, "that Government of United States will show prudence and renounce actions pursued by you, which could lead to catastrophic consequences for peace throughout world."[21]

By midday on October 23, the marathon meeting of more than twelve hours, with a short break for sleep, was finally over. Khrushchev and the members of the Presidium went to lunch. The situation seemed to be back under control. The previous night Khrushchev, like Kennedy during the first day of the crisis, had opted for military action. If Kennedy argued in favor of a strike, Khrushchev would be prepared to use tactical nuclear weapons, followed by strategic ones if the situation required them. But with Kennedy taking a moderate line and choosing a blockade instead of a strike or invasion, Khrushchev, to his relief, did not get a chance to approve the use of tactical nuclear weapons. For all the differences between the two men, and the misjudgments and misunderstandings that accompanied their search for the right decision, they had something in common. They dreaded a nuclear war.